

T6: Final Team Paper

Rutgers Club Field Hockey

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Management Skills

Professor Van Zant

12/2/25

We conducted our case study on the Rutgers club field hockey team, a co-ed competitive field hockey team that operates in affiliation with Rutgers University. Our primary contact is Eda Taskaya, who is the club/team president and is now in her second year in the position. The organization currently consists of 34 active members who have all paid dues for this year, and all are women. There are currently 6 members in management positions, including the president, VP, social chair, captain, secretary, and treasurer. The Rutgers club field hockey team is an active member of the National Field Hockey League. The organization is located at: College Ave Gym, 130 College Ave, New Brunswick, NJ 08901.

Moreover, the general contact information is:

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They hold practices at the Busch club field (Bartholomew Rd, Piscataway, NJ 08854), and executive discussions and meetings are held virtually. We are unable to verify their official start date, but we can confirm based on alumni game participation that the club has existed for at least a decade. Eda Taskaya estimates the club has been around for around 15 years.

The primary output problem that we will be focusing on is the lack of team cohesion, which translates to a lack of synergy during games. The team feels that on-field performance could improve if the team worked more as a real team. President Eda Taskaya states that the team could “work more cohesively during games”.

From what we observed, the club is successful at initial recruitment and gains interest through the club fair, involvement fair, and social media outreach; however, it requires attention in the area of consistency and commitment from members. In other words, the issue is not recruitment but retention, as new members often struggle to integrate into the established group.

According to Eda, while practices typically have a member turnout of about 25-30 people, games usually see a drop to about 15 people who attend. This could be because new members might feel a lack of social acceptance within the club, as there is already an established group of people who consistently attend games and practices, hindering integration and weakening the connection between themselves and the club. Because they don't feel as included, they don't feel the urge to be committed. Moreover, according to Eda, she and the captain are the most involved in communication and leadership with the other members. Possibly incorporating more interaction with other executive members could create stronger bonds between all members. Additionally, other collaborative activities that aren't necessarily practice or games and involve all members could be further implemented to possibly see an increase in team cohesion during matches, as well as increased overall turnout to field hockey events, as it could create more of a deep, platonic bond aside from just playing field hockey together.

Based on Eda's perspective, encouraging girls to sign up for the club doesn't seem to be much of a problem. However, she does explain that once these members join, many of them aren't engaged and committed to making the club better on the field. They need to act and move like a unit in order to reach the outcome they want. With girls constantly floating in and out of the equation, they have expressed that they, at times, find it difficult to connect with them out on the field. With girls not coming to practices consistently and just maybe showing up for a game or two, the other members feel like they aren't given the opportunity to connect with them or learn their style of play, since they aren't around each other enough outside of the game situation. The ability to know how your team members play and communicate on the field is what makes the team able to work as a unit. The reason there is this difference between the manager and employees in this scenario, the president and the general members, is because Eda is more

focused on creating a welcoming environment where attendance is flexible and as something that will work itself out. While the general members are the ones being directly impacted by the inconsistent attendance, which makes it hard for them to build that necessary team chemistry.

We identify group norms as an opportunity for improvement within the Rutgers Club Field Hockey organization, and our conversations with Eda have allowed a foundation for us to form a more complete picture of the issue and what contributes to it. Eda did note concerns about on-field chemistry, but we wanted to add to her perspective by seeing the issue from all sides, most notably the general members. We wanted direct feedback from players who are both regulars and some who are not as committed to the organization. We conducted an interview with a general member of the club, “Sunny”, to add a more specific perspective from the players, as well as sending out a survey to all members of the club, both on the executive board and traditional members to get a deeper view into member tendencies and experiences. Taken together, we dove deeper into the output problem of team cohesion and understood what contributes to it.

For our first interview, we spoke with club president Eda Taskaya in an attempt to gain insight into how the club operates at the top, how functions work among the rest of the executive board, and how they interact with the club's general population. As club president, Eda's role includes making announcements to the rest of the team and serving as the general head of transportation, an ambassador at outward-facing meetings, interacting with the general club sports e-board, and performing smaller day-to-day tasks.

During her interview, Eda identified a symptom of our identified issue but not its root cause. She observed that the team could benefit from better cohesion, stating that the team could “work more cohesively during games”. However, she did not connect this lack of cohesion to the

underlying issue of inconsistent practice attendance and a broken performance-reward link. She did not acknowledge the severity of the problem, in contrast to Sunny, who identified the issue, inconsistent member attendance. We believe that Eda has the opinion that the club is in overall better health than the general members do. She acknowledged commitment as a possible issue and root cause of the team's performance; however, she did not present it as an urgent or serious issue, stating that the lack of commitment that comes with joining a club sport is acceptable when compared to a larger stage. Although Eda herself could not identify any severe issues within the organization, her recommendation of team cohesion aligns with our identified issue of the organization. This issue stems from having inconsistent member attendance in practice and games, leading to difficulty with cohesion in games. Due to this, consistent members are forced to adapt to infrequent members' playstyles who show up at an inconsistent rate during games. It is also important to note that while Eda's observation about cohesion aligns with our identified output problem, her failure to identify its cause highlights a gap in the organization's board's understanding of the members' challenges.

For our second interview, we interviewed Sunny, who is a second-year member of the club field hockey team, and she plays as a general team member. She is an active member and participates in both practices and games. She is a member who has firsthand experience with how attendance is inconsistent during practices and how it affects team cohesion.

During the interview, Sunny identified inconsistent practice attendance as the main issue affecting team cohesion and game performance. She states that having inconsistent member attendance and having new members show up at games leads attendees to adapt mid-game to unfamiliar playing styles. She mostly emphasizes that cohesion is hindered when the team has to adapt/adjust to new or inconsistent members. Sunny believes that the lack of clear expectations

and enforceable rules causes inconsistency. Even though executive board members have stated that “you have to show up to practice to play games”, it is not enforced. Sunny states that members disregarded this, and they still show up to games whenever, regardless. Moreover, Sunny explicitly stated in the interview that “it is difficult to play with people you don’t practice often with” and that adapting to new playing styles mid-game can lead to “less cohesiveness”. She does believe that implementing expectations such as attending two practices before each game to be able to play would encourage consistency and strengthen the team overall.

The overall conclusions about the output problem based on these interviews are that the lack of chemistry on the field during the game is the result of people not consistently showing up to the practices. Both parties we interviewed agreed that game time chemistry was a problem the team was facing, but Eda (the president) didn't see commitment as an issue, simply because of how flexible the team is in order to accommodate everyone's schedules. On the other hand, Sunny saw that the flexibility of the team was an issue that needed to be fixed to overcome the problem of not being able to connect on the field. We think that the team must address commitment and how it impacts how much people play in the game. The specific evidence that is leading us to the conclusion we are drawing about the issue the team should be prioritizing is the fact that in both interviews this issue was mentioned and we believe that in order to fix the issue of not connecting on the field they need to address the issue of the members who show up to practice compared to who shows up to the game. We have set up a survey that will be sent out to solidify the evidence these interviews have provided us with. The flexibility of the team and lack of strict commitment are what are causing the problem we believe should be prioritized. Evidence to support this comes from Sunny’s interview, where she says, “there is definitely inconsistency ... people show up less and less, but they still show up for the games and are still

allowed to play.” She is then asked if there were to be less inconsistency, would there be more cohesion on the field, which is the issue Eda mentioned in her video. She responded, “ I think it is very difficult to play with people you don't practice with just because you don't know their playing styles. That also falls on the board for allowing people to play who don't come to practice.” The board must address this inconsistent attendance of practices, compare it to who is coming to the games and who is getting playing time, and establish some form of performance-reward link to help grow the team's connection. By enforcing practice attendance and notifying members that this will lead to greater playing time in games, it will give them a motive to attend practices, which leads to a reward. Hopefully, this will allow them to win more games.

The course concept we identified as our problem was broken expectancy theory links, specifically relating to instrumentality, the performance-reward link. To clarify, the root cause of the cohesion issue is unclear expectations (broken instrumentality), which lead to inconsistent attendance, which then results in weak on-field cohesion. During our meeting with Eda, the president, she discussed how the team has a lax policy when it comes to attendance, where members are generally allowed to attend games and practices as they wish, with attendance only being taken for identification purposes. This most likely contributes to the lack of consistency between game and practice attendance, as it means that the expectations regarding commitment are unclear, leading the club members to just show up whenever they want, affecting team cohesion in the process. We propose that the e-board implement more rigid policies in order to encourage more commitment, such as having to attend two practices prior to the game in order to be eligible to play. This would fix the broken link in the expectancy chain between performance and reward, as it would lead to a clear link between showing more effort by attending practices

and getting rewarded through game time, and it would clearly outline expectations in order to continue participation in the club. Without it, there's no incentive to put in more time to practice.

We utilized a survey to quantify our issue identified through a series of multiple-choice questions, collecting data such as their attendance rate and their opinion on the severity of the issue, with specific questions tailored to allow us to quantify this problem. This was sent out to roughly 34 members. We allowed a week and a half for responses to come in. The survey was open for a week and a half and was structured in three distinct parts to collect different types of data:

Attendance Frequency: The first two questions gathered self-reported data on participation rates. These were multiple-choice questions with categorical options (e.g., "I attend all", "most", "half", or "none") for both practice and game attendance.

Scaled Opinions: The following four questions used a 1 to 5 scale to gauge members' perceptions of the problem. However, it is important to note that two different scales were used:

For three questions: assessing how inconsistency affects team chemistry, how flexibility causes inconsistency, and whether set expectations would lessen inconsistency, the scale ranged from 1 ("Not affected at all") to 5 ("Greatly affected").

For the final question: "I believe practices are efficient and help maximize in-game performance", the scale used 1 ("Strongly Disagree") to 5 ("Strongly Agree").

Open-Ended Feedback: Finally, two short-answer questions at the end allow for targeted and qualitative insights on the issue we identified: "Do you believe that the organization's flexibility and low-pressure environment limits team chemistry?" and "What motivates you to come back to each practice or game?"

This mixed-methods approach allowed us to gather both quantitative data for statistical analysis and qualitative data for deeper contextual understanding. Using data from the multiple-choice, we were able to quantify the attendance rates for the practices and games. We can translate the inconsistency into set numbers, and it allows for an easier statistical read, which we observed for patterns. Using data from the scaled questions, we were able to observe the opinions of the club members directly related to our identified organizational issue. We used their response to quantify the severity of the issue based on the frequency of the members' responses and whether it was truly an issue that interfered with team cohesion. The open-ended questions also serve as further valuable information with targeted opinions from members and a more detailed look into how members view our identified issue.

The metric we chose is appropriate for quantifying the output problem, as the scale-based questions will provide clear numerical data that can be represented through a graph, and clear indications can be observed. Since we have a scale-based approach to most questions, if we observe that the average response to "team chemistry is affected by inconsistent attendance" and "To what extent do you feel that if there were set expectations for all members inconsistency would lessen?" is 3.5 or higher, it indicates that the majority of members feel the root cause of their game performance and poor cohesion is due to inconsistent attendance, which is a result of broken expectancy theory links. Moreover, for the question regarding "set expectations would lessen inconsistency", if it averages a score of 3.5 or higher, it also indicates strong member support that implementing some sort of attendance expectation or a reward for attendance would lead to more consistent practice attendance. Along with this, our short open-ended questions provided personal perspectives on the questions asked previously. The mix of qualitative data and

personal experience/evidence-based helps quantify the severity of the output problem, which is member inconsistency, and how this leads to hindered team performance at games.

Based on the survey responses, we quantified the severity of the organization's output problem, which is member inconsistency, and the resulting effect on the expectancy theory links. Using both attendance data and scaled opinion data. The most prominent numerical metric that captures the severity of the issue is the average perceived impact of inconsistent attendance on team chemistry, which came out to 3.45 on a 5-point scale (sample size of $n=11$). This value is important because it directly showcases members' opinions about how much impact the inconsistency problem has on the team's performance, cohesion, and game outcomes. In an ideal setting, a healthy organization with reliable attendance would expect this metric to fall close to 2.0 or below, meaning players perceive only mild or occasional disruption. A score near 3.5, however, shows that members feel the issue is not only present but actively affecting the team regularly. This demonstrates that the output problem is more than a minor issue, but rather something that members commonly notice during games and throughout their season.

Another key metric comes from the question asking whether setting expectations would reduce inconsistency, which yielded an average score of 3.64 out of 5. This number suggests strong agreement that the current system of high flexibility, low pressure, and no consequences for skipping practice, contributes directly to the performance issue. This aligns with the broken expectancy theory link the organization is facing, which is that members do not believe that attending practice leads to better performance or greater rewards, because players can still show up to games and play regardless. The fact that this question's average is even higher than the

chemistry question strengthens our argument that the issue is rooted in the "performance-reward" link being unclear or nonexistent.

The attendance frequency data reinforces this breakdown. Only 18.2% of respondents reported attending all practices, and another 18.2% reported attending most practices. Additionally, 27.3% attend very few practices, and 18.2% attend none at all. Having nearly half of the respondents regularly attending practice reflects the greater issue of inconsistency and shows the team's biggest weakness. There's no confirmed baseline for sports teams for the target to hit for practice attendance, but ideally, it would be as close to 100% as possible. This would ensure the best team chemistry, consistent improvement, and overall enhance preparation and playtime. However, with the majority of the respondents reporting not even attending most practices, the team is far off from that goal. The normal or "desirable" goal for practice would be to have at least 50% attend most of the practices in addition to the 18.2% attending all practices, ensuring consistency in the amount of practice time and allowing players to build connections with each other.

The game attendance numbers show a similar gap. While attendance is stronger for games than practices, only 18.2% attend all games, and nearly 55% attend most games. The fact that game attendance is significantly higher than practice attendance highlights the exact expectancy breakdown we identified, which is that members see value in showing up to games, which is seen as a reward, but not in practices, the "hard work", because the club does not differentiate between the two when assigning game time.

All in all, the survey data reveal that member inconsistency is not just mildly present and inconsistent, but it is severe enough to disrupt the core functioning of the organization. Based on the interviews with Eda, the club president, and Sunny, the club member, they both expressed

that the rate of attendance should be more than what the organization is at right now. Although a specific value or percentage for attendance was not provided by either representative of the club, they both believe that the organization is currently failing to meet the desirable value. Players themselves believe that inconsistency harms chemistry (3.45), that expectations would reduce the problem (3.64), and their own attendance inconsistency confirms the broken performance-reward link, as a lack of motivation to attend practices because the effort does not influence rewards. This imbalance demonstrates that the output problem is significant, quantifiable, and directly tied to the broken expectancy theory links that define the organization's current structure.

The recommendation that our group makes to Eda and the Club Field Hockey team is that they should implement a clear and measurable Key Performance Indicator (KPI) system that defines what the performance expectations are and how they link directly to rewards, such as starting positions or more playing time. When using a well designed KPI framework, it is able to strengthen each link in the expectancy theory chain. General members are able to gain confidence that the effort they are putting in will translate into playing time and performance as KPI's clarify what exactly is expected. KPI's have been used widely by the biggest sports teams around the world. FC Barcelona, a well known men's soccer team from Spain, has actually implemented the KPI strategy in more areas than just their players; they have incorporated it in their financial and fan engagement teams. For the players specifically, they measured their performance and kept a clear record of the goals, assists, and injuries. Through this, they were able to see an improvement in player performance and a 30% reduction in injuries. FC Barcelona's successful outcomes show how a properly structured KPI system can improve both the performance of players and their well-being (1). Another example of a sports team that was able to strengthen its expectancy links with the use of KPI is the Golden State Warriors. Through

the use of KPI coaches are able to track different markers for their players on and off the court. Using this information to not only find areas where their players need improvement, but also to look at other teams and how their players are performing compared to them (2). A third and final example of how KPI's have helped others succeed is with Amazon. They use KPI's to track everything from company-wide sales growth to advertising goals, which create clear expectations for what performance should look like. By making these expectations measurable, their employees and partners are able to see how their effort connects to the outcomes and strengthen the effort to performance link (3). Altogether, these examples show that clear, consistent, and measurable KPI's will not only create a higher drive for performance across to the different industries and sports teams, but they also help strengthen every link in the expectancy chain. Demonstrating that implementing a similar system would benefit Eda and the club field hockey team.

Bibliography

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Appendix

Individuals Interviewed:

Eda Taskaya

Sunny

Initial Interview Questions:

Name, Position, Grade, and how long she has been part of the team?

Brief history of club field hockey, and how long has it been around?

What does your executive board structure look like?

What does communication look like between the executive board and members?

Do you think the relationship between members and the executive board is positive?

What is the process of joining the club field hockey team?

What are the costs associated with joining the club field hockey?

Are players responsible for equipment costs?

What is the gender split of the club? Why?

How many members participate in practices, and how does that correlate to game participation?

How many members come back after the first practice?

How do you promote member retention and commitment?

How do you promote membership and commitment among current members?

What are some organizational issues you can identify?

Where would you like to see improvements?

Tailored General Member Interview Questions:

Name, Position, Grade, and how long she has been part of the team?

What does communication look like between the executive board and members?

How does the executive board promote member retention and commitment?

Is there an inconsistency between members appearing at practices and at games?

Do you think that having less inconsistency between members could lead to better cohesion within the team at actual games?

Do you think that if there were expectations or incentives for members, like going to at least x number of practices for that semester, it would motivate more members to attend and then lead to better team cohesion on the field?

Where would you like to see improvements?

Sunny Interview Notes:

We interviewed Sunny, a member within Club Field Hockey, on Wednesday, Oct 23, and asked questions tailored towards our selected output problem, which is member inconsistency and how that affects team cohesion in games. Sunny states that there is inconsistency when it comes to practices, and members tend to show up less frequently as the semester progresses, but they still attend games and are allowed to play regardless of practice attendance rate. She states that it is difficult to play with people that you do not practice with often, as you are not knowledgeable about their specific playing styles. Moreover, this causes conflict, especially when you have practiced with 3 members consistently and now have to adapt your own playing style to accommodate a member who comes to games but only attends practices ever so often. It ultimately leads to less cohesion and having to adapt mid-game due to infrequent members

playing in games. She believes that setting member expectations and norms can lead to more consistent member attendance during practices and better cohesion in games. However, she also states that the executive board has tried to encourage practice attendance through stating that “you have to show up to practice to play at games” but members do not acknowledge this lightly set rule. Moreover, Sunny states that she would look to see more scoring occurring in actual games, but this is also held back due to inconsistent practice attendance by members. When members are accustomed to playing with a set number of members and someone new appears to play during games, it hinders cohesion and performance on the field as they have to adapt playing styles to compensate for a new player.

Eda Interview Notes:

The person we interviewed is Eda Taskaya, who is the president of the club field hockey team. She has been on the team for 3 years and has been president for 2 years. According to Eda, the club has been around for at least 15 years. The positions are secretary, president, vice president, treasurer, captain, and social chair. Communication between the executive board and members within the club occurs through GroupMe or in-person practices. Mostly, the president and the captain are the ones providing information to the general members. According to Eda, there is a lot of trust between the executive board and its members. Moreover, issues are vocalized and brought up to the executive members; they communicate effectively through problems, concerns, or general questions. The process of joining the club field hockey team usually occurs through the initial club fair, via DMs, or email, stating interest in the club. Moreover, everyone is welcome and nothing is forced, practices, games, etc. There are no costs associated with joining the team and participating in practices; however, to be able to participate

in games, you must pay dues, which are \$25 for home games and \$50 for both home and away games. Moreover, there is also a \$90 package for those who want to play for both the fall and spring semesters in all games. General equipment, such as sticks, is provided; however, mouthguards, shinguards, and protective gear are for the members to buy. The current gender split of the club is made up of a majority of females, with rare occurrences of guys joining.

Moreover, Eda believes the reason for this is that many people are not aware of the fact that it is a Co-ed team, although they do strive to advertise actively. Along with this, she believes that since men's field hockey is not big in the States, many men are not very interested in or informed about it. For each practice, about 20-30 girls participate. This translates to about 15-20 people for away games, and there tend to be more people in attendance for home games. After the initial practice, the club sees a majority retention rate, with a rough estimate of about 10 people not returning after the first practice. The club promotes a very welcoming and understanding environment, nothing is forced, and all is voluntary. Their primary goal is to have fun rather than be competitive. They promote and advertise their club through Instagram and TikTok. Areas for improvement, as mentioned by Eda, are more targeted towards working better together during games and also connecting further with the overall team and its members, as it is still relatively new due to the start of a new semester.

Survey Questions:

Multiple Choice: How would rate your attendance to practice

Multiple Choice: How would you rate your game attendance?

Scale: 1-5: To what extent do you feel that team chemistry during games is affected by inconsistent member attendance?

Scale: 1-5: To what extent does flexibility and low pressure environment of the organization affect inconsistency?

Scale: 1-5: To what extent do you feel that if there were set expectations for all members inconsistency would lessen?

Scale: 1-5: I believe practices are efficient and help maximize in-game performance.

Open Ended: Do you believe that the organization's flexibility and low pressure environment limits team chemistry?

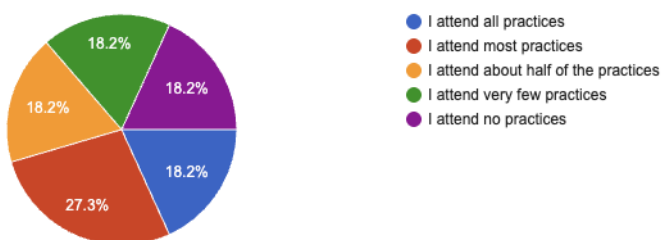
Open Ended: What motivates you to come back to each practice or game?

Survey Results -

How would rate your attendance to practice?

11 responses

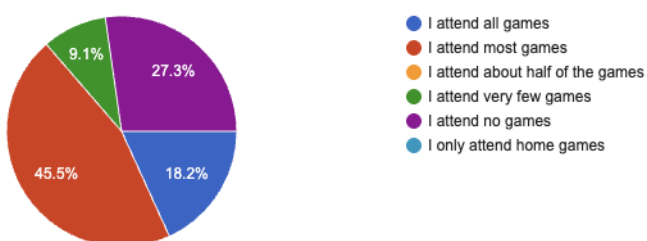
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How would you rate your game attendance?

11 responses

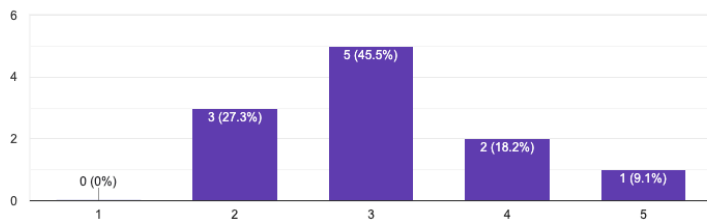
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To what extent do you feel that team chemistry during games is affected by inconsistent member attendance?

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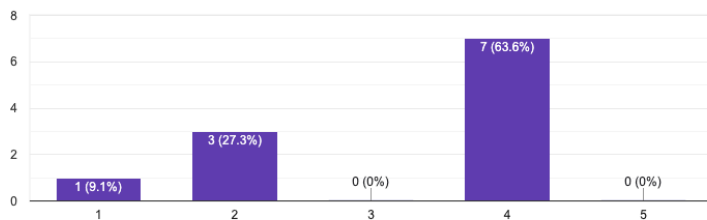
11 responses



To what extent does flexibility and low pressure environment of the organization affect inconsistency?

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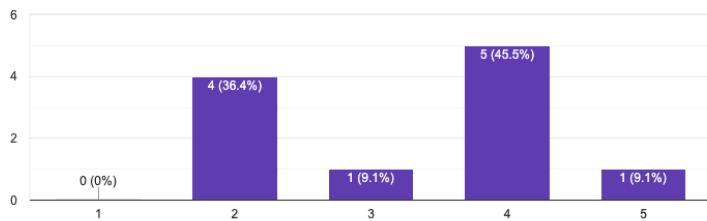
11 responses



To what extent do you feel that if there were set expectations for all members inconsistency would lessen?

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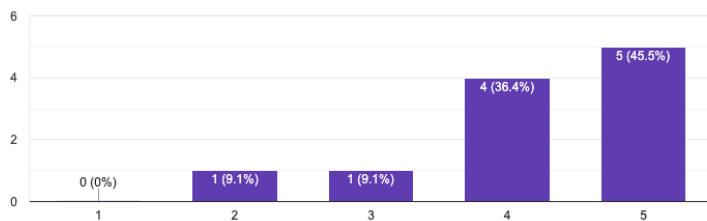
11 responses



I believe practices are efficient and help maximize in-game performance

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11 responses



Appendix Contact Log link -

<https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/12UMSZda9gU4WYN9LceAjOSMj7GXXKZb6JM4rXVjEnhX0/edit?usp=sharing>